

**A JUNK FOOD DIET, COUPLED WITH LACK OF EXERCISE, AFFECTED CHILDREN'S MENTAL AND PHYSICAL ABILITIES**

learn new skills, cultivate fresh hobbies, and spend more time with their families. The interactive nature of online learning helped shy and introverted children to emerge from their shells. "The actual value of something is best realised when one imagines being deprived of it. If there was no online learning to fall back on, one wonders how the past two years would have panned out," says Karthik.

Some parents, too, expressed satisfaction with what online learning did for their children. "My children got more personalised attention. Earlier, they were just another face in the class," says Pune-based entrepreneur Adarsh Patel, who has two children, aged 7 and 9.

As we move towards a post-Covid world, experts recommend a hybrid model of learning, combining the best of both worlds. Modern schooling, says Sugata Mitra, educational theorist and founder of the Hole-in-the-Wall project, a TED-prize winning experiment in self-learning, was developed 200-odd years ago under the British empire. The system was designed to be unidirectional, from the teacher to the students, who are then tested on what they learn. "Its purpose back then was to produce clerks and civil servants," he says. "Today, memorisation of facts isn't as important as accessing, understanding, and applying knowledge. With the rise of the internet, students have to start thinking critically when given the tools and triggers for learning, in classrooms where education is collaborative, not one-directional." Hole-in-the-Wall has already shown the way. In 1999, it placed a computer in front of children with no previous computing experience in a slum in Delhi. Through group learning, the children figured out how to use the machine on their own. "When the human mind figures out something on its own, it retains that learning for much longer and applies the knowledge more effectively," says Dr Nimesh Desai, psychiatrist and director of the Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences in Delhi.

Expert after expert has also advocated making affordable education accessible to all children, plugging the digital gap and customising hybrid models to cater to the diverse needs of students. With the pandemic having lasted two years, a majority of the parents have been keen for schools to reopen. However, concerns remain, both among parents and children, about the unvaccinated status of the under-15 children. Dr Anil Sachdeva, a paediatrician at the Sir Ganga Ram Hospital in Delhi, says most of his patients want to get their children vaccinated so that they can return to school. Mumbai student Akash Khattar, 15, took his vaccination almost as soon as the programme was opened to those between 15 and 18 years so that he could attend his tuition classes in person. "I would like to score well in my final year so that I can go to a good college and have a secure and happy future," he says. "I could not go outside as I have elderly grandparents. Now that I am vaccinated, my mother feels confident about letting me go."

Schools and teachers have been equally eager to have students back in the classrooms. To compensate for any learning losses, they are considering increased personalised tuition for students, special doubt-clearing sessions, regular assessments of their learning capacity and counselling sessions for those with lingering stress or anxiety. Realising the need for supplementary teaching and to build "a resilient mechanism for education delivery', the government in its budget this year expanded the 'one class-one TV channel' programme of eVIDYA from 12 to 200 channels. It also made a commitment to develop high-quality e-content in all spoken languages to be delivered through internet, mobile phones, TV and radio with the help of digital teachers.

Covid's children have, after all, have survived a biological Armageddon early on in life. Much of that trauma will hopefully fade, but before that happens, the next few years will have to be spent re-learning things we have long taken for granted. ■

*–with* **Romita Datta and Shelly Anand**